CZ 🔶 BNB
@cz_binance
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Keep Your Crypto #SAFU in 2026

Realizing the original article (https://www.binance.com/en/blog/from-our-ceo/421499824684900429) is too long and wordy, I made a condensed version. Match security measures to the value of your holdings and your technical ability. Address

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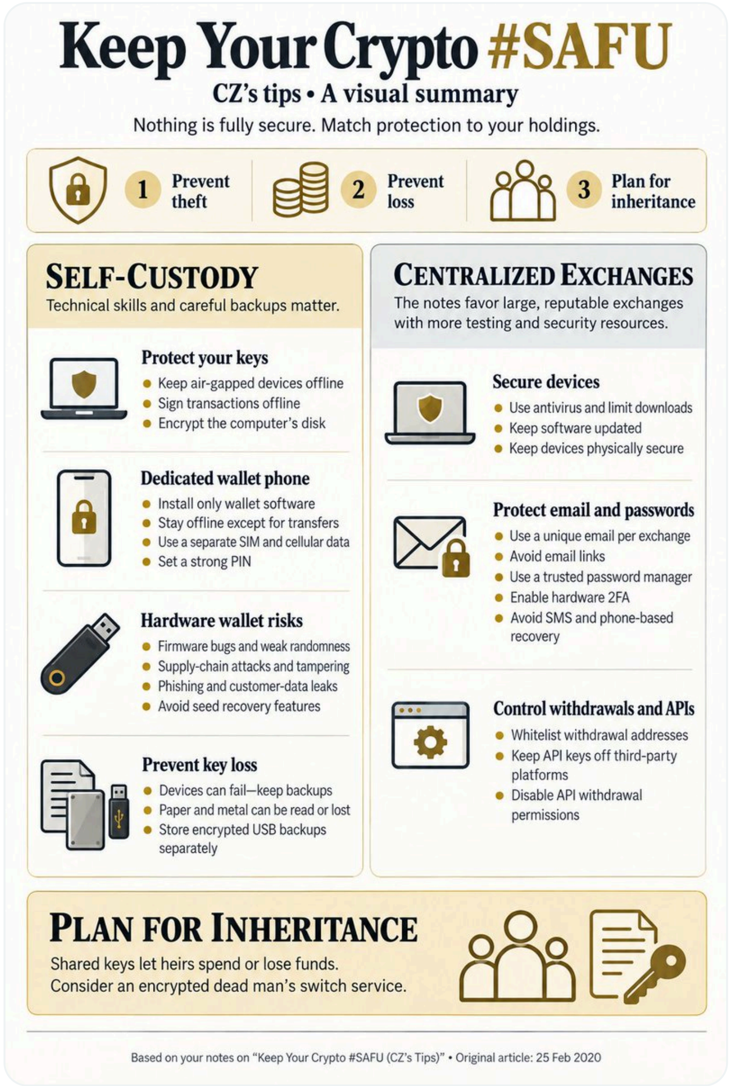

Keep Your Crypto #SAFU

CZ's tips • A visual summary

Nothing is fully secure. Match protection to your holdings.

1 Prevent theft | 2 Prevent loss | 3 Plan for inheritance

SELF-CUSTODY

Technical skills and careful backups matter.

Protect your keys
- Keep air-gapped devices offline
- Sign transactions offline
- Encrypt the computer's disk

Dedicated wallet phone
- Install only wallet software
- Stay offline except for transfers
- Use a separate SIM and cellular data
- Set a strong PIN

Hardware wallet risks
- Firmware bugs and weak randomness
- Supply-chain attacks and tampering
- Phishing and customer-data leaks
- Avoid seed recovery features

Prevent key loss
- Devices can fail—keep backups
- Paper and metal can be read or lost
- Store encrypted USB backups separately

CENTRALIZED EXCHANGES

The notes favor large, reputable exchanges with more testing and security resources.

Secure devices
- Use antivirus and limit downloads
- Keep software updated
- Keep devices physically secure

Protect email and passwords
- Use a unique email per exchange
- Avoid email links
- Use a trusted password manager
- Enable hardware 2FA
- Avoid SMS and phone-based recovery

Control withdrawals and APIs
- Whitelist withdrawal addresses
- Keep API keys off third-party platforms
- Disable API withdrawal permissions

PLAN FOR INHERITANCE

Shared keys let heirs spend or lose funds.
Consider an encrypted dead man's switch service.

Based on your notes on "Keep Your Crypto #SAFU (CZ's Tips)" • Original article: 25 Feb 2020

Match security measures to the value of your holdings and your technical ability. Address three priorities: prevent theft, prevent accidental loss, and provide for inheritance.

Self-custody

Private keys authorize access to funds. Seed phrases generate those keys. Anyone who obtains either can control the associated crypto.

Self-custody requires secure devices, reliable backups, and a workable recovery plan.

1. Prevent key theft

Computers

- Use a dedicated offline computer to store keys and sign transactions.
- Install software from official sources using clean removable media.
- Check downloads for malware and reported security issues.
- Use supported software that permits offline signing.
- Encrypt the disk and protect the computer physically.

Mobile phones

- Use a dedicated phone, reset before installing the wallet.
- Install only necessary wallet software; avoid rooting or jailbreaking.
- Keep the phone offline except when transfers or updates require connectivity.
- Use a strong passcode and maintain physical control.
- For fully offline wallets, plan how to update software and move funds securely.

Hardware wallets

- Choose an established device and protect it against theft or tampering.
- Keep the connected computer or phone secure.
- Verify the destination address on the hardware wallet before approving transfers.
- Protect backups as carefully as the device itself.

Hardware wallets reduce exposure of private keys but remain vulnerable to software flaws, physical attacks, and insecure backups.

2. Prevent key loss

Maintain multiple protected backups in separate locations.

- Paper: Simple to create, but vulnerable to damage, loss, transcription errors, and unauthorized reading.
- Metal: More durable, but still vulnerable to loss and unauthorized reading.
- Encrypted USB drives: Allow geographically separated backups but require strong encryption and technical care.

Avoid photographs or screenshots of keys that may sync to cloud accounts. Research backup and encryption tools, restrict access, and ensure the recovery process works.

3. Plan for inheritance

Provide a recovery process without unnecessarily exposing funds during your lifetime.

Sharing keys gives recipients immediate spending access and creates additional opportunities for loss or theft. Storing keys with an intermediary carries similar risks.

A dead man's switch can release instructions after prolonged inactivity. Research and test the service before relying on it.

Do not place unencrypted keys or backup passwords in scheduled messages. Encrypt recovery instructions for the intended recipient—for example, using their PGP public key. Recipients must understand the process and protect the private key needed to decrypt it.

Centralized exchanges

Exchanges manage custody and infrastructure; users remain responsible for account security.

Evaluate reputation, security resources, testing practices, and the sustainability of the business model. Treat unusually generous incentives or unclear revenue sources cautiously. Exchange custody carries counterparty risk.

Secure your account

1. Protect computers

Use a dedicated computer where practical. Enable antivirus and firewall protection, minimize installed software, and limit downloads. Protect other devices on the same network.

Install operating-system and application updates promptly. Disable unnecessary automatic downloads in messaging apps.

2. Protect email

Use a separate email address for each exchange. Enable strong two-factor authentication, preferably a hardware security key. Avoid phone-based recovery that could expose the account to SIM-swap attacks.

3. Use unique passwords

Create a strong, unique password for every account and store it in a suitable password manager. Protect the device running the manager; malware can undermine its safeguards.

4. Enable two-factor authentication

Use 2FA on exchange and email accounts. Authentication codes add protection, but malware and phishing sites may capture or relay them.

5. Use hardware security keys

Where supported, secure exchange, email, and password-manager accounts with hardware security keys. Their website-specific authentication helps resist phishing.

6. Avoid SMS authentication

Prefer authenticator apps or hardware security keys. Attackers who take control of a phone number may intercept SMS codes.

7. Whitelist withdrawal addresses

Restrict withdrawals to approved addresses to make unauthorized transfers more difficult.

8. Protect API credentials

Keep API keys private and prevent unauthorized use. For asymmetric authentication, retain the private key securely and provide only the public key to the exchange.

Lost API credentials can generally be replaced; wallet keys require a separate backup strategy.

9. Complete identity verification

Identity verification can support ownership checks, investigations of suspicious activity, and inheritance procedures. Understand the exchange's documentation requirements.

10. Secure devices physically

Use strong screen locks and protect phones, computers, hardware wallets, and backups. A phone may provide access to email, exchange accounts, and authentication codes simultaneously.

11. Avoid phishing

Open exchanges through trusted bookmarks or carefully typed addresses. Do not enter credentials after following unsolicited email, text, or social-media links.

Treat unexpected contact from purported exchange staff or public figures cautiously.

Choose a custody mix

Allocate funds between exchanges and personal wallets according to technical ability, security practices, and access needs.

Self-custody requires independent key protection and recovery. Exchange custody requires trust in the provider and strong account protection. A separate wallet can provide access during exchange maintenance.

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